

Gathering and analysing information that has already been published

Almost all the dissertations written for these Master's-level programmes have been based on primary research carried out by the writer. That is, the writer has gathered primary data from respondents, by interviews, surveys or other means, and analysed it. However, a small number of dissertations have been based on analyses of data that has already been gathered for another purpose – this is called secondary data. Secondary data can include: data gathered and published by organisations, such as reports and press releases; reports on companies or issues published in books, newspapers, or on websites, or in documentary material broadcasted on television or radio; biographies; works of fiction; material obtained from databases; and material previously published in academic papers.

Many of these examples of secondary data can be analysed using academic theories and frameworks, and can thus form the basis of a dissertation. A limitation of secondary data, however, is that it has been gathered, or constructed, and published for reasons other than your research and therefore it needs to be scrutinised carefully as to whether it will answer your research question. It also needs to be carefully scrutinised for credibility – or as to the extent it reliably represents an underlying reality (Bryman, 2016). Claims on a company website, for example, about the values and quality of the company, are written to make a positive impression on their readership; similarly statements from company spokespeople often do not represent the underlying reality of company practices, and so should be treated with caution. Of course, when you gather data in interviews, your interviewee may be trying to make a favourable impression on you, and you need to think about the credibility of what they say, but at least with interviews you are able to construct the questions, and you can probe for further information.

This paper briefly discusses how examples of published materials might be used in researching your dissertation.

Company reports and press releases

Reports generated by companies about events, progress or plans may be fruitful material for analysis. They may contain information about priorities, actions, plans or decisions that can be of value to the researcher. But as Bryman (2016, p. 561) says they need to be recognised as documents 'written with distinctive purposes in mind, and not simply reflecting reality'. Bryman (2016) argues that if we wish to investigate that underlying reality, it is best to gather additional information by other means.

For example: in research into bringing about process improvements in healthcare organisations, Boak (2014) analysed project reports to the Department of Health in England from 27 healthcare teams that had been sponsored by the Department to bring about improvements. He also carried out 24 interviews with team leaders. He analysed the data through a lens of team learning, using academic theories about this phenomenon to analyse the information he gathered. This was not a subject that had been promoted or expected by the Department in commissioning the reports, therefore he brought a fresh perspective to the material.

In another example, Chatterjee and Hambrick (2007) examined the effect of CEO narcissism on a company's strategy and results. They assessed the narcissism of chief executive officers (CEOs) by measuring the prominence of the CEO's photograph in annual reports, the prominence of the CEO in press releases, the CEO's use of 'I' in interviews, and his/her remuneration relative to the second-highest-paid firm executive. They correlated this with publicly available information on the company's performance.

In both of these cases, the reports and other publications were in the public domain.

Other company publications

You may be able to access documents or other publications from within an organisation that are not in the public domain, such as surveys, minutes of meetings, plans, job descriptions, person specifications, communications from senior managers – such as blogs or tweets – and so on. In such cases you should ensure that you have the permission of the owner of the data to use it in your research. For example, if you want to use data from a job satisfaction survey carried out by the HR department, you should get permission from a responsible person in that department to use the material.

An example: in an innovative use of material already collected by his organisation, Papworth analysed recordings of eight successful supervision sessions of trainee therapists, with an average length of 39 minutes. The Hersey and Blanchard (Hersey *et al.*, 2001) Situational Leadership model of styles of leadership was used in the analysis. This was a Master's dissertation that later formed the basis of a journal article (see Papworth *et al.*, 2009).

Reports on companies or issues

Reports that have been published on companies or issues and which are in the public domain may provide valuable data for analysis in a dissertation. For example, at least three books have been written about the accounting scandal at the US company Enron, and to the material within them you could add newspaper reports published at the time that the scandal broke. The current opioid addiction crisis in the USA, and the associated malpractice by a certain pharmaceutical companies, has generated a number of books and newspaper articles, which may provide enough substance for a dissertation on unethical management behaviour. As with any other sources of data, you must look at each item critically and assess its credibility.

TV documentaries about events or organisations may also hold the promise of providing material about practices in management or leadership, which can be analysed with frameworks of academic theories. Two issues that particularly apply to this kind of material are a) whether there is enough information available for a dissertation, and b) the purposes of the publishers of the information. A one-hour documentary, for example, is unlikely to provide enough material by itself for an in-depth analysis. The purpose of the publication of the material must also be borne in mind – TV programmes have been described as 'infotainment', a combination of providing information and also entertainment: the material that is selected for broadcast will have been chosen with both purposes in mind.

However, if sufficient material can be found, carefully scrutinised for credibility, and you acknowledge the possible influences of editing to maximise entertainment, this may be a useful source of secondary data. One example is the campaign by UK chef Jamie Oliver to improve the nutritional value of school dinners: this was covered in four one-hour TV programmes broadcast in 2005, which are still available on the web, and has been revisited by a number of newspaper articles since then. It provides an example of an individual attempting to achieve change in a complex social system, and could be analysed using theories and concepts of change leadership and management.

At the time of writing this paper, much is being published every day about the coronavirus pandemic and the ways in which various governments and government agencies are attempting to manage it. It is tempting to analyse some of these attempts within a framework of leadership and management of crisis situations (there is an academic literature on this). However, perceptions of whether measures are effective or ineffective seem to vary from commentator to commentator, and it appears likely that matters that are concealed now will only emerge over time, so perhaps this is a subject (or, rather, these are sources) too recent to be safe ground for research if we are interested in touching Bryman's 'underlying reality'. There are a small number of factual accounts of particular events – see, for example, the Reuter's report on a series of decisions in UK government (Grey and Askill, 2020) and Kettle's (2020) commentary on leadership, based on the report - but probably not enough material of sufficient quality at this time for a dissertation.

Biographies

Biographies and autobiographies of managers, leaders, innovators, statesmen and politicians may provide interesting and valuable information for research into leadership. Autobiographies in particular should be carefully scrutinised for credibility, as they are likely to be self-serving to some extent. Good quality biographies, where the writer has had good access to the subject can provide fruitful material for analysis.

For example, Michael Mumford and colleagues have developed theories about 'pragmatic' 'charismatic' and 'ideological' leaders through analysing biographies of political leaders (Mumford, 2006). Mumford and Van Doorn (2001), for example, include analysis of material from over a dozen biographies of Benjamin Franklin, to put forward the concept of a 'pragmatic' style of leadership.

The biography of Steve Jobs – a contemporary innovator and leader – by Walter Isaacson is an illuminating account of Jobs's behaviour (Isaacson, 2011, see also Isaacson, 2012) that could provide material for analysis using academic frameworks. Jobs has also been the subject of numerous articles in newspapers and magazines. The usual cautions apply about careful scrutiny of all of this material.

Works of fiction

Depictions of managerial and organisational life in works of fiction may provide material that can be analysed using appropriate theories about leadership, management, change and so on. A series of novels, or a TV series, where there is a substantial amount of material may be richer ground than single books or films. A colleague once began an assessment of the Harry Potter books, wondering if Hogwarts could be analysed as a form of learning organisation – but no journal article ensued. Obviously, most works of fiction aim to entertain their readers in some ways, rather than portray an

accurate picture of organisational life. Your analysis might inquire into the way in which management, leadership, or other organisational phenomena, are depicted in the material, without too much concern about whether this accurately represents reality. It is important to bring relevant academic theories to any analysis of fiction, as with the other kinds of published material.

Databases – quantitative data sets

Useful material for analysis may be stored on databases that you can access. For example:

- the Fame database has company information for UK companies and you have access to FAME (<https://libguides.yorks.ac.uk/az.php?a=f>) through your YSJ account
- the World Value Survey (<http://www.worldvaluessurvey.org/wvs.jsp>) this data base is freely accessible; it contains world wide data on topics such as politics, work, religion, feeling happy, national cultural values, and much more: the World Value Survey was used as the basis of a paper by Waening *et al.* (2018).

The key idea when using existing databases, is that you analyse the data in a new way which works for your own research, so you are making a contribution and you are not just replicating existing work. The key contribution of the paper by Waehning *et al.* (2018) was to investigate regional within-country cultural differences as opposed to national differences.

When using databases:

- make sure the dataset can help you answer your overall research question
- ensure that you reference those databases accordingly
- make sure you are doing something new with the dataset and you are not just replicating or even copying other peoples' work.
- if in doubt, talk to your supervisor

Meta-analysis

Meta-analysis is an approach that is taken by professional academics in researching and writing journal articles and reports. It entails gathering and analysing research papers on a particular topic and identifying patterns of findings. It is usual to specify the search criteria of the meta-analysis in detail, as in a systematic literature review, so that the search can be duplicated by other researchers.

This approach can work well if there is a reasonably large amount of literature that has not already been subjected to a meta-analysis. For example, Schyns and Schiller (2013) carried out a meta-analysis of studies on destructive leadership. Their initial search found 260 articles; they then applied explicit selection criteria to reduce the number to 61, which they analysed (see Appendix 1 for details of their search strategy). Where there is little academic literature about a topic, a meta-analysis is likely to be too insubstantial for a journal article – or for a Master's degree dissertation.

Summary

Material that has already been published in some form may be useful data to analyse for your dissertation. It might supplement primary data you gather for your research, or it may form the whole of the data that you analyse. Apply the same qualitative or quantitative techniques to analyse this data as you would if it were primary data you had gathered yourself. You need to apply relevant academic theories to analyse the data, and your need to show that you have analysed in a new way, and not simply replicated any analyses already contained in the published data.

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Appendix 1

Description of the search strategy used in Schyns and Schiller (2013, p. 144)

6.1. Search strategy and inclusion/exclusion criteria

In order to identify articles to be included in the meta-analysis, we used three approaches (following procedures of other meta-analyses; (Judge & Piccolo, 2004; Judge, Colbert, & Ilies, 2004; Hershcovis & Barling, 2010). First, we reviewed the reference list of Tepper's (2007) overview article. Second, we conducted a literature research in PsycINFO, Google Scholar, and Web of Science to identify further studies. As there is at this stage not a unitary term in use for destructive leadership, we used a variety of search terms, such as abusive supervision, abusive leadership, destructive supervision, and destructive leadership. We restricted our search to keywords, title, and abstract. The cut-off date for this search was end of September 2010. Table 2 depicts the search terms used and the number of articles found for each of those terms. Third, we also contacted colleagues working and publishing in this field on an individual basis to uncover some unpublished research.

Using all search strategies outlined above, we found 260 articles. The PsycINFO search yielded 104 studies. All other searches combined yielded another 156 articles.

We used several strategies to identify studies relevant for our meta-analysis. First, we reviewed the abstracts of the articles found. Based on the criteria outlined below, we discarded 44 articles after reading the abstracts. In the second stage, we reviewed the remaining 216 articles. Of those articles, 61 were deemed relevant, 152 were not relevant, and 3 were not available. Reasons for non-inclusion in our meta-analysis were: The articles reported no quantitative data (e.g., review or theoretical articles as well as qualitative papers were excluded), the study did not refer to hierarchical relationships (e.g., some studies referred to peer, rather than leadership behavior), the study did not use behavior as a unit of measurement (e.g., some studies focused on traits), the study did not take place in a formal work context (e.g., some studies comprised samples in mentoring relationships), the article was not written in English, the study did not include a form of destructive leadership (see above, we excluded studies that used laissez-faire leadership as a form of destructive leadership), or the study did not refer to personal leadership (e.g., some studies comprised structural or HRM type of leadership). We also excluded studies that did not differentiate the perpetrator of the negative behavior (e.g., some studies focus on workplace aggression in general independent of who shows the aggression, e.g., some studies reported in Hershcovis, 2011). Finally, some articles did not contain enough information to be included in our meta-analysis. We also excluded articles that reported on the same data set for a second time.